



CASE FILE — YOUTH EDUCATION SERIES

Youth Intervention & Prevention Initiative

Youth & The Law

What you actually need to know before you turn 18 — your rights, real Ottawa scenarios, and the law behind them.

LET'S SEE HOW MUCH YOU ACTUALLY KNOW.

OPENING CASE · SHOW OF HANDS**THE SCENE**

Officers lead a man away in handcuffs at night. His hands are cuffed behind his back. On the ground beside him, evidence bags are laid out and numbered.

Looking at this, how many of you think this person is guilty?

THE HONEST ANSWER

You have no idea. And that's not a trick — that's the entire point of Canada's justice system. Everyone is presumed innocent unless and until a court decides otherwise, based on evidence, beyond a reasonable doubt. A photo, an arrest, even a criminal charge is not a conviction.

KEY TERMS • BEFORE WE START

Four Words You'll Hear All Class

Keep these in your back pocket — everything today connects to one of them.

- 1 Presumption of innocence — everyone charged with a crime is considered innocent unless and until a court says otherwise.
- 2 Investigative detention — a brief, temporary hold based on reasonable suspicion that someone is connected to a specific crime.
- 3 Reasonable grounds — the legal threshold police need before they can arrest someone.
- 4 Burden of proof — in court, the Crown must prove guilt beyond a reasonable doubt. The accused doesn't have to prove anything.

WARM-UP • TRUE OR FALSE

How Much Do You Actually Know?

Show of hands for each — we'll check your instincts against the real law as we go.

1

Police can search you whenever they want.

2

If you're under 18, you can't be criminally charged.

3

Police can't pull you over unless they saw you commit an offence.

4

A social-media post can't get you in legal trouble because it's “just online.”

5

If your friend steals something and you don't touch it, you're automatically fine.

6

If you're 18, you can legally drink alcohol anywhere.

01

SECTION 01

Your Rights & Police Powers

What the Canadian Charter actually protects — and what it doesn't.

CHARTER RIGHTS • SECTION 2(B)

Freedom of Expression

- 1 The Charter protects your freedom of thought, opinion and expression, including speech and media.
- 2 That doesn't mean every action involving speech is automatically legal.
- 3 The Criminal Code still covers knowingly spreading false information meant to injure or alarm someone, and repeated messages meant to harass.

BRIDGE TO SOCIAL MEDIA

Freedom of expression has real limits — and that matters a lot once we get to what happens online.

CHARTER RIGHTS · SECTIONS 8, 9 & 10

Can Police...?

Before we explain the law, vote first. For each one: yes, no, or depends?

Search your backpack?

Search your phone?

Stop your car?

Search you after arrest?

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS

None of these are a simple yes or no — it depends on legal authority and circumstances. A backpack or phone each need their own justification (phones especially, since they hold far more personal information than a bag ever could). A car can be stopped for a range of lawful reasons under traffic law, not just a witnessed offence. And a search after arrest is generally limited — tied to safety and evidence — not unlimited license to go through everything you own.

CHARTER RIGHTS • SECTIONS 8 & 9

Search & Detention, Explained

- 1** Section 8 protects you against unreasonable search or seizure. A search is generally reasonable when it's authorized by law, the law itself is reasonable, and it's carried out reasonably.
- 2** Section 9 protects you against arbitrary detention. Talking to police is not automatically the same as being detained.
- 3** Police can conduct an investigative detention only when specific legal conditions are met — reasonable grounds to suspect you're connected to a specific crime, and that detaining you is necessary.

DON'T SAY

“Police need a warrant every time.” — too simple, often wrong.

SAY INSTEAD

“Whether police can search or detain you depends on the circumstances and their legal authority.”

CHARTER RIGHTS • SECTION 10

If You're Detained Or Arrested

One of the most important things to actually know.

- 1 The right to be informed promptly of the reason.
- 2 The right to retain and instruct a lawyer without delay.
- 3 The right to be informed of that right.
- 4 The right to challenge the legality of the detention.

THE POINT

This isn't about “how to avoid getting arrested.” It's about knowing what's happening to you and how to respond.

CHARTER RIGHTS • EXIGENT CIRCUMSTANCES

The Locked Door

Police receive a 911 call. It sounds like a child saying “come to my house” — no address, no other details, and no answer when they call back. Officers arrive at a house they believe is the source. The door is locked.

Can police enter immediately?

Do they need a warrant first?

What if the homeowner comes to the door and says everything is fine?

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS (R. V. GODOY)

This falls under exigent circumstances. Case law — R. v. Godoy — allows police to enter without a warrant when they have a genuine, reasonable concern for someone's immediate safety, like an unresolved emergency call. That authority is narrow: it lasts only as long as it takes to check on the safety concern, not to search the home. And a homeowner saying “everything's fine” doesn't automatically end it — officers still have to be reasonably satisfied there's no emergency.

02

SECTION 02

How An Investigation Really Works

One stolen phone. Nine legal decisions.

CASE WALKTHROUGH · OPEN DISCUSSION

Someone steals an iPhone from the Rideau Centre.

You're the officer who takes this call. What's the very first thing you actually do?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Let students call out ideas and write a few on the board. Don't correct them yet — the next slide walks through how the real investigation gets built, step by step.

CASE WALKTHROUGH · STEP BY STEP

Building The Investigation

Every step needs its own legal authority — none of it happens just because police feel like it.

- Victim statement
- Cell phone tracking
- CCTV footage
- Search warrants
- Witness accounts
- Arrest
- Interview
- Crown review

ASK THE ROOM

Which of these steps do you think is hardest for police to get right — and why?

CASE WALKTHROUGH • EVIDENCE

Circumstantial vs. Corroborative Evidence

1

Circumstantial evidence suggests something indirectly — it invites an inference rather than proving a fact outright, like a similar hoodie on a CCTV clip.

2

Corroborative evidence independently supports another piece of evidence, making the overall picture more reliable, like a witness statement that matches the CCTV timeline.

ASK THE ROOM

If all police have is one grainy CCTV clip of someone in a similar hoodie, is that enough on its own to arrest? Why or why not?

03

SECTION 03

You Just Got Your Licence

Driving, impaired driving, and what “zero tolerance” actually means.

DRIVING • TRAFFIC STOPS

Can Police Actually Pull You Over?

- 1** Traffic law gives police authority to stop drivers in a range of circumstances.
- 2** The Criminal Code allows mandatory alcohol screening: if an officer has an approved screening device and is lawfully exercising police powers, they can demand a breath sample from someone operating a vehicle.

COMMON MYTH

“Police can only stop me if they saw me speeding.” Not true.

REALITY

Traffic enforcement, investigating an offence, vehicle concerns, impaired-driving screening, and other lawful purposes — more specific than a blank check.

DRIVING • IMPAIRED DRIVING

Zero Tolerance — Under 21

0%

Alcohol allowed while driving — for drivers 21 and under, and G1/G2/M1/M2 novice drivers. Zero-tolerance rules apply to cannabis too.

NOT JUST ALCOHOL

Ontario's zero-tolerance rules for young and novice drivers apply to cannabis as well.

DRIVING • ROADSIDE TESTING

“I’m Not Drunk”

1

“I only had one.” “I don’t feel high.” The legal question isn’t just how you feel.

2

Ontario’s tools include roadside screening equipment, sobriety tests, and other investigative measures.

SCENARIO

How can an officer assess possible impairment?

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS

Observations, conversation with the driver, driving behaviour, physical coordination testing, approved screening tools, and further investigation where legally authorized. Roadside testing is an investigative tool — not a game to “beat.”

04

SECTION 04

Alcohol, Cannabis & Ethical Calls

What legalization did and did not change — and the calls officers have to make.

ALCOHOL & CANNABIS · ONTARIO LAW

What The Law Actually Restricts

- 1** Under 19 in Ontario, you generally can't possess, consume, attempt to purchase, purchase, or otherwise obtain liquor — with narrow statutory exceptions, like certain situations involving a parent in a private residence.
- 2** The Cannabis Act specifically restricts young people too — including limits on possession amounts and rules around distribution and selling to minors.

THE TAKEAWAY

Being under 18 changes the legal picture for both alcohol and cannabis. Every time.

ETHICAL DILEMMA · OPEN DISCUSSION

Your best friend commits impaired driving, and you're the officer who finds out. Do you arrest them?

FACILITATOR NOTE

There's no reveal slide after this one — let it stay genuinely open. Then share: officers take an oath that applies even when enforcing it is personally hard. Discretion exists in policing, but the law doesn't bend based on who's involved.

05

SECTION 05

Social Media & Misinformation

When does a joke become a legal problem?

SOCIAL MEDIA • CRIMINAL CODE S.372 & S.140

“It's Just A Joke”

- 1 Someone posts “there's a dangerous person at the school” — knowing it isn't true.
- 2 Someone falsely reports that another student committed a crime.
- 3 Someone repeatedly sends messages specifically intended to harass another person.

SCENARIO

Is any of that just “internet stuff,” or could it be a crime?

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS

Section 372 covers knowingly conveying false information with intent to injure or alarm. Section 140 — public mischief — covers intentionally misleading police into investigating something that didn't happen, including a false crime report. “I told police my friend was kidnapped, as a prank” is not a joke to the law.

SOCIAL MEDIA • WHO'S RESPONSIBLE

Someone Films A Fight

It happens in almost every high school: two students fight, someone records it, someone posts it, other people share it and comment on it.

Person throwing punches?

Person filming?

Person who posts it online?

Person encouraging it?

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS

There's no single answer that covers all four — it depends on what each person actually did and intended. The person fighting may face an assault charge. But filming, posting, and encouraging aren't automatically consequence-free either: depending on intent, they can carry their own legal exposure and school consequences. Turning someone's worst moment into content isn't neutral.

ASSAULT • CRIMINAL CODE

Assault ≠ Only Unwanted Contact

- 1 Assault includes intentionally applying force to another person without consent, as well as certain threats or attempts to apply force.
- 2 “We both agreed to fight” doesn't automatically mean no crime occurred — the circumstances matter.

SCENARIO

Two students fight. Someone records it. Someone posts it. Other students share it.

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS

Now there are multiple layers stacked together: the physical incident, a possible criminal offence, school consequences, privacy and reputational harm, online behaviour, and witnesses turned into evidence. Don't turn someone else's worst moment into entertainment.

**If you wouldn't say it to a police officer,
a judge, your principal, and your parents —
think before you post it.**

Not because everything online is illegal. Because screenshots exist, posts spread, context gets lost, and online actions have real offline consequences.

06

SECTION 06

Theft & Peer Pressure

“It's only \$20” — and how people get pulled into things they didn't see coming.

THEFT • CRIMINAL CODE

Value Doesn't Make It Legal

1

The Criminal Code defines theft as fraudulently taking or converting something, without colour of right, with the required intent.

2

The dollar amount doesn't change whether it happened.

SCENARIO

Your friend takes a \$30 item from a store. You don't take anything. You know they're stealing. You leave with them. Are you in trouble?

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY SAYS

There's no automatic answer either way. Criminal responsibility depends on what you actually did, knew, and intended — and participating in an offence can involve more than physically committing the final act. “I didn't touch it” doesn't automatically mean you're in the clear.

THEFT · OTTAWA POLICE SERVICE

This Is Happening In Ottawa

79.2%

Clearance rate for the Retail Theft Pilot Project, launched April 1, 2026 and running until September 30, 2026, focused on organized and repeat retail theft.

BY EARLY JUNE 2026

279 cases handled · 221 cleared with charges · ~79.2% clearance rate

PEER PRESSURE • GETTING PULLED IN

Recruitment Doesn't Look Like Recruitment

- 1** It usually sounds like: “Can you take this somewhere?” or “Don't worry, nobody will know.”
- 2** Students get pulled into situations through friends, older acquaintances, pressure, money, social media, wanting to fit in, or being promised something in return.

WARNING SIGN, NOT OPPORTUNITY

If someone older is asking you to carry, store, deliver, or participate in something illegal — that's a warning sign, not an opportunity.

07

SECTION 07

“I’m Under 18, So I’m Fine.”

The Youth Criminal Justice Act — you are not off the hook.

YCJA • YOUTH CRIMINAL JUSTICE ACT

The Youth Criminal Justice Act

- 1 The YCJA governs Canada's youth justice system — designed differently from the adult system.
- 2 Youth crime can have consequences, but the response recognizes reduced maturity and emphasizes rehabilitation and reintegration.
- 3 For certain non-violent offences by a young person with no prior finding of guilt, extrajudicial measures are presumed adequate to hold them accountable — handled outside full court proceedings, aiming to repair harm and involve family and community.

DON'T SAY

“First-time offenders just get a warning.”

REALITY

The YCJA provides several possible responses. What happens depends on the circumstances.

08

SECTION 08

A Day In Policing & Careers

Instead of a list of duties — one real shift, and where a career here can go.

A DAY IN POLICING · ONE SHIFT

0700 To 1600

- 07:00

 Coffee.
- 07:50

 Domestic assault call.
- 10:30

 Missing child reported at Rideau Mall.
- 12:00

 Shoplifting in progress.
- 13:30

 Mental health crisis call.
- 16:00

 Drowning in the canal.

ASK THE ROOM

Before we talk about what really happens at each of these — which one do you think is hardest to respond to, and why?

A DAY IN POLICING • TOOLS

The Technology Behind The Job

- Drones
- Cell phone extraction
- CCTV networks
- License plate readers
- DNA analysis
- Social media investigations
- Digital forensics

CAREERS • SWORN & CIVILIAN

Policing Is Bigger Than Patrol

SWORN

- Homicide
- Youth
- Guns & Gangs
- Cybercrime
- Intelligence
- Tactical
- Canine
- Marine
- Forensics
- Fatal Collision Investigation & Reconstruction
- Recruiting

CIVILIAN

- Communications (911 / dispatch)
- Crime Analysts
- Special Constables
- Prisoner Response Unit (PRU)
- Youth in Policing Initiative (YIPI)
- ...and more

09

SECTION 09

What Would You Do?

Rapid-fire questions — call on the room before revealing each answer.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO? • QUESTION 1 OF 6

Police approach you: “Can I talk to you for a minute?” Are you automatically under arrest?

Yes

✓ No

WHY

A police interaction alone doesn't automatically mean arrest or detention.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO? • QUESTION 2 OF 6

Can police ALWAYS search you?

Yes

No

✓ Depends on the circumstances

WHY

Section 8 protects against unreasonable search — but it doesn't prohibit every search. It depends on the legal authority and circumstances.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO? • QUESTION 3 OF 6

You're 17 and driving with any alcohol in your system. Legal?

Yes

✓ No

WHY

Ontario requires zero alcohol for drivers 21 and under, and for novice drivers.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO? • QUESTION 4 OF 6

You post a fake emergency as a joke. “It's just social media” — true or false?

True

✓ False

WHY

Knowingly false information, or deliberately causing police to investigate something that didn't happen, can trigger Criminal Code offences like public mischief.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO? • QUESTION 5 OF 6

Police get an urgent 911 call and the door is locked. Can they ever legally enter without a warrant?

✓ Yes — in narrow emergency circumstances

No, never

WHY

Under exigent circumstances (see *R. v. Godoy*), police can enter without a warrant when there's a genuine, reasonable concern for someone's immediate safety — but only as far as needed to resolve that concern.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO? • QUESTION 6 OF 6

Only the person throwing punches in a filmed fight can get in legal trouble.

True

✓ False

WHY

Filming, posting, and encouraging a fight can also carry legal and school consequences, depending on intent — not just the physical act itself.

THREE THINGS TO REMEMBER

Know Your Rights. Know Your Responsibilities.

- 1** Police are there to enforce the law — but they also operate within the law.
- 2** You have rights — but rights aren't a free pass to break laws.
- 3** Being under 18 doesn't mean there are no consequences. Your actions online can have offline consequences, and your friends' decisions can put you in difficult situations too.

IF SOMETHING FEELS WRONG

Get help before it becomes a bigger problem — talk to a trusted adult, or reach out to Ottawa Police Service.

SOURCES & CREDITS

Where This Came From

- Justice Canada — Charterpedia (Sections 2(b), 7, 8, 9, 10) and case law on exigent circumstances (R. v. Godoy)
- Justice Laws — Criminal Code (theft, assault, public mischief, false information, impaired driving)
- Justice Laws — Youth Criminal Justice Act
- Justice Laws — Cannabis Act
- Ontario.ca — Impaired Driving & New Drivers (G1/G2 rules)
- Ontario — Liquor Licence and Control Act, 2019
- Ottawa Police Service — Youth resources & Retail Theft Pilot Project news release

Content current as of August 2026. This deck simplifies complex law for a classroom setting — have your supervising officer review the search, detention, party, SFST, YCJA, and exigent-circumstances slides before presenting. This is a reference slide — no need to present it live if you're tight on time.